

executed through the Foreign Military Sales (FMS) route of the US government. The Acceptance of Necessity (AoN) for the purchase of the MQ-9Bs was granted by India's Defence Acquisitions Council on June 15. Since this was the first step in a long process involving several tiers of negotiations, it is understood that the first delivery of the drones may take several years. Clearly, from the AoN to the final clearance by the Cabinet Committee on Security, it is a long haul before the Indian military has its coveted drones. Moreover, the Congress and the Trinamool Congress have complained that the estimated cost of the MQ-9Bs is too high and their technology not the most updated one; they have even compared the agreement to the controversial deal to purchase 36 French-made Rafale fighter jets.

In response to these objections, the government has said that India aims to negotiate a competitive agreement with the US in a

INDIA'S SILENT SQUADRONS

In recent years, the Indian military has increased its use of UAVs for surveillance, reconnaissance and strike operations. Among the prominent ones in service:

MQ-9B

DEVELOPED BY: San Diego-based firm General Atomics Aeronautical Systems

The MQ-9B SeaGuardian and SkyGuardian (left) are variants of the MQ-9 Predator B or Reaper. Ideal for ISR and a variety of strike capabilities

NO. IN SERVICE: Two SeaGuardian drones are being used by the Indian Navy for its ISR operations since 2020. Under the recent deal, navy will get 15 SeaGuardians; army and IAF 8 SkyGuardians each



HERON

DEVELOPED BY: Israel Aerospace Industries (IAI)

Also known as Machatz-1, the Heron is a Medium Altitude Long Endurance (MALE) UAV usually used for Intelligence, Surveillance and Reconnaissance (ISR) activities. Israel has offered its upgraded Heron TP to India

NO. IN SERVICE: 90. It was first used in 2006



SEARCHER

DEVELOPED BY: Israel Aerospace Industries

Reconnaissance and surveillance UAV first developed in the 1980s. Also used for artillery adjustment

NO. IN SERVICE: 108. Used by IAF since 2002. The army is the biggest user of Searcher drones. Also used by the navy



HARPY, HAROP

DEVELOPED BY: Israel Aerospace Industries

Harpy and its upgraded, larger version Harop, are loitering missiles or 'kamikaze' drones, which serve as electro-optically guided attack weapons

NO. IN SERVICE: 160 Harop drones used by the IAF



SWITCH

DEVELOPED BY: Navi Mumbai-based firm ideaForge Technology

SWITCH UAV is a Vertical Take-Off and Landing (VTOL) aircraft and fixed wing hybrid UAV ideal for surveillance

NO. IN SERVICE: 200-plus SWITCH drones are being used by the army along the LAC since 2021. It has ordered around 200 more advanced version SWITCH tactical drones